such sources as digitised video and audio, sensor data, email, documents and the unformed text that fills Facebook, Twitter and other social media websites. People don't usually mind companies collecting internal data, if it means that the companies will return the favour in terms of better quality of service or even price cuts. It's the collection of unstructured external data that's starting to tick people off, because it rouses in them a sense of betrayal of trust against the websites and services that are expected to handle their personal data and hold it sacrosanct. Ah, time for the naivety of Internet users to end.

You're the product being sold

If you're not paying for it or getting something for free, then you're the product. This is an old business mantra, and most people already know this. The basis of the business model is you availing of a product or service for free in return for having your personal data be mined and shared with all kinds of companies that can use this data for their benefit. Usually, this data is used to sell advertising space or intelligence to improve advertising efficiency. In the age of Big Data, this old business adage is under increased focus.

According to a Business Insider report, "the average global Internet user spends two and a half hours daily on social media, and their activity reveals a great deal about what makes them tick." Having woken up to the fact that social networks constitute a huge amount of consumer Big Data, now social networks are making significant investments in putting this data to work – largely for themselves and to some extent also for their users. If social networks like Facebook, Google+ and others successfully connect the dots between their users' relationships, interests and spending habits, they stand to gain a lot as they'll be able to provide their users with personalised content, and in turn advertisers will be able to hyper-target users.

Here are some more insights into the unique data each social network is collecting about their users, according to the Business Insider report examining the kind of information popular social networks collect and how that data fits into their product strategy:

IF YOU'RE NOT PAYING FOR IT OR GETTING SOMETHING FOR FREE, THEN YOU'RE THE PRODUCT.

- Facebook collects 63 different pieces of data for its API – more than any other social network. The mind boggling scale of information shared on Facebook and consumed by its users is so immense that Facebook can provide a window into what people care about with surprising accuracy. Facebook's "like" button is pressed 2.7 billion times every day across the web. All that is information Facebook is collecting about you and millions of others to decipher your tastes and even accurately predict them.
- Google+ helps the search engine giant contextualise its trove of search data, offering hints and clues as to why people search for certain kinds of information. This helps in generating patterns about user behaviour with greater accuracy. The relationship goes in the other direction too – the number of "+1s" and other Google+ data are now a top factor in determining how a web page ranks in Google's search results.
- Twenty-two per cent of LinkedIn users have between 500-999 first-degree connections on the social network, and 19 per cent have between 301-499. Just the way people endorse and recommend each other on LinkedIn is creating a new way of understanding recruitment and retention patterns on the popular professional social network.
- At its peak on August 3, 2013, Twitter was processing 143,199 tweets per second globally. These tweets provide a crucial real-time window into the news and information that people care about the most. Fifty-two per cent of Twitter users in the U.S. consume news on the site (more than the per cent who do so on Facebook), according to Pew Research data.
- Hundreds of thousands, if not millions, of product images are pinned to personal pages (called "pinboards") on Pinterest every day. They represent a unique window into millions of shoppers' aspirations. More than 17 per cent of all pinboards are categorised under "Home," while roughly 12 per cent fall under "Style/Fashion." What's more, 80 per cent of pins on Pinterest are repins, so images of products have a long shelf life, long after the initial pin has been posted. Imagine what advertisers would be willing to pay anyone who puts them in touch with potential customers with such high aspirational value for all sorts of commodities and products?

Does this mean that data gathering is wrong? Of course not. And it's practically impossible for websites to not gather any data about you while you're on the web.

THE BIG OPPORTUNITY

IBM inarguably provides the most simple definition of Big Data by explaining the way it spans three main dimensions: Volume, Velocity and Variety.

Volume: Enterprises are awash with ever-growing amounts of data of all types, easily amassing terabytes – even petabytes – of information. Volume refers to the ability of turning 12 terabytes of tweets created each day into improved product sentiment analysis and converting 350 billion annual meter readings to better predict power consumption.

Velocity: Sometimes even 2 minutes is too late. For time-sensitive processes such as catching fraud, Big Data must be used as it streams into your enterprise in order to maximise its value. With it, you can scrutinise 5 million trade events created each day to identify potential fraud and analyse 500 million daily call detail records in real-time to predict customer churn faster.

Variety: Big data is any type of data – structured and unstructured data such as text, sensor data, audio, video, click streams, log files and more. New insights are found when analysing these data types together. With it, companies can monitor 100's of live video feeds from surveillance cameras to target points of interest and exploit the 80% data growth in images, video and documents to improve customer satisfaction.